

Episode 81: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative! *Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes (Part 2)

The other day, when I casually turned on the TV, there was a programmes about 50 years of news history for Fuji TV's 50th anniversary. In it, footage of the tsunami disaster at Okushiri Island was shown, and among the debris left after the tsunami receded, there was a family's photo album that had been destroyed and was all messed up.

A family album.

Beyond the loss of life, I thought it would be painful to lose memories with family. While houses and belongings can somehow be managed, once you lose an album filled with family memories, it never comes back.

And then I suddenly thought: ah, we don't have albums at our house.

Our household has gone all digital photography now, and while the photos are stored on everyone's computer hard drives, we don't bother printing them out and putting them together in albums.

Really, photos should be made into albums you can hold in your hands and look at.

Work is also becoming increasingly digital with paperless progress. That's better for work, but I think memories should still be something you can hold in your hands.

Well, if we had children, we probably would have taken lots of photos (nowadays it would be video?) and made lots of "growth albums."

Ah, come to think of it, we barely have any photos of the two of us together...

This is something I really need to think about in the future...

Now then.

Have you purchased them, everyone? *Casshern Sins* DVD & Blu-Ray. This week I'm delivering part 2 of "*Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes."

Episode 7: "The Woman in the High Tower"

Script: Yoshida Reiko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Tominaga Mari / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

This episode 7 was actually made as episode 8 in production. Originally there was one episode before this, production episode 7, but due to various circumstances it was moved to the back as production episode 18 (broadcast episode 17). So from here on, production episode numbers and broadcast episode numbers were misaligned. We on the production side naturally talked in terms of production episode numbers, so when someone occasionally talked in broadcast episode numbers, it got confusing (laughs).

So broadcast episode 7. This is also a complete story in one episode. Lyzbel, alone in some factory, making bells. She mysteriously entices the visiting Casshern, plotting to use him as material for the bells she creates.

This story also progresses quietly, but Lyzbel being nicely "sick" and somewhat mysteriously sensual - I remember getting a bit excited reading the storyboard (laughs).

In *Casshern Sins*, we do things throughout not just reflecting spatial colours, but expressing the characters' emotional movements and states by adding strange colours to the characters themselves, and we intentionally do this in several places in episode 7. Like the scene where Lyzbel snuggles up to Casshern at the top of the tower.

The scene near the end of the first half where she tries to put Casshern to sleep was directed by assistant director Nakayama-san, and the mysterious green lamp colouring came from Nakayama-san's image. *Casshern Sins* tends to have a lot of purple-based special colouring (←the director's preference), but ah, green tones work well too! It turned out to be a good scene.

For me, the robots playing cards at the beginning and those cards are my favourite parts (laughs).

Episode 8: "A Hymn of Hope"

Script: Yamato-ya Akira / Storyboard: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Direction & Animation
Director: Ito Tatsufumi / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

The episode where songstress Janis appears. This episode also builds up colours scene by scene steadily.

The Janis I first conceived had light brown hair, but with "she's a strong woman, right?" (director), we arrived at red hair to bring out her inner strength. Ah, that overlaps with Lyuze (laughs).

The climax is still spectacular - Janis's singing scene and Casshern's big battle set to her singing voice. Perhaps due to coincidence, from episode 8 onward, episodes with Akimoto-san as colour direction tend to have "tight schedules + intense battles"...

Actually, the battle scene outside this music hall - both the robots and backgrounds had colours that were a bit too deep, and when we filmed it, it became too dark and you couldn't tell what was what. So we had the photography department adjust the screen brightness.

Episode 9: "Flowers Blooming in the Valley of Death"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Aoki Tetsuro / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

In this story, rumours are heard that Luna might be alive, and Casshern's group's travel purpose is determined for now. It's a very touching story about Niko and Bolton.

Right around episodes 7-11, I was in the thick of *GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie*, and partly because of that, I left Niko and the doll's colour settings half-finished (sweat). I got the director's approval at quite the last minute.

For episode 9, I deliberately reduced scene-by-scene colour changes and made it a structure that carefully follows the performances of Niko, the apple, and Bolton.

In return, the finishing was tough with all the flowers (laughs). The flower fields, petals, and flower decorations worn on heads were quite challenging apparently, and quite a few cuts had to be redone in finishing inspection. During rush checking, colour direction Kohinata-san watched the cut where Bolton tears off and throws away the flower decorations and said "...after all that hard work (tears)" and was crying (laughs).

From this episode, Matsumoto Kenji-san joined the art staff. Matsumoto-san's uniquely deep artistic style really hit the spot with Niko's poignancy.

Episode 10: "A Man Imprisoned by the Past"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard: Ito Naoyuki / Animation Director: Hayama Jun'ichi / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Setting aside Casshern and the others for a bit, this is Dio and Leda's story. With Leda pulling strings in the background, the "Dio Corps" is launched. And Down makes his appearance.

I was thinking I'd decide on this "tattered Down" together with the "cool Down" setting that appears in flashback scenes. But the "cool Down" setting came up after key animation work had already progressed (animation proceeded with rough settings). So I left the colours undecided until quite the last minute (sorry (sweat)).

And that "tattered Down" - in the character setting that was first submitted and approved, he was a clean-faced character, but when it came time to decide colours, painting according to the settings and creating the colour scheme gave an "hmm, something's lacking" impression. Apparently Umakoshi-san thought so too: "Would it be bad to add some colour divisions?" So it became an urgent setting revision, resulting in that kabuki-style? wrestler-style? kumadori colour-divided face.

Meanwhile, the "cool Down" appearing in flashback scenes is a solidly built handsome man (laughs). Being Luna's guardian, I tried matching the colour scheme of his clothing with Lyuze's. This episode also avoided extreme colour changes and kept to natural colours matched to the background art. However, what the director told me later was about the Luna and Down flashback scene.

Actually, I had made this scene to look normal coloured like other scenes, but the director said "Let's use colours to give meaning that flashback scenes are flashback scenes." "If we're making normal scenes look ordinary, we should give some variation to flashback scenes."

Episode 11: "Under His Own Mission"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard: Sendo-ji Takuma / Direction: Hatano Kohei / Animation Director: Hayama Kenji / Colour Direction: Nakano Tomoaki

Episode 11 was produced by Tatsunoko Production (竜の子プロダクション). The first outsourced production episode of the *Casshern Sins* series. From direction to animation to photography, all handled by Tatsunoko Production.

I had worked with director Hatano since *Hakaba Kitaro* (墓場鬼太郎). However, he apparently didn't know I was doing colour design until the colour direction meeting, so when I walked into the meeting room, as soon as he saw my face he shouted "Whaaaat!? No way?" (laughs).

This episode is also a "this is the world Casshern exists in" type story. Casshern trapped in crystal and Friender trying bravely to save him encounter a group of humans and robots travelling in search of Luna's location. Friender opens his heart to their leader, Jin.

On his 10th appearance, the dog who's already often forgotten (burst) plays a big role.

Every time I make scene-by-scene colour direction, I tend to forget to make Friender (laughs). But this time I certainly didn't forget (or rather, I started with Friender).

This story also used almost no special colouring. I made it naturally matched to the background art.

In the latter half, there's a scene where companions pressure Jin to "kill Casshern." It's a rather heavy, tense scene, but Jin persuades everyone against it. From the cut where Jin declares "I won't kill Casshern" (right around when the insert song starts playing), I changed from the low-saturation colour direction used until then to normal colour direction. From this point where the atmosphere of the situation changes, I wanted to restore "brightness" and "vitality" to the character colours.

You probably can't tell unless you watch really carefully, but I tried to create the screen atmosphere including such small details.

Episode 12: "Colouring the Time I Lived"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Minatsu Tatsuya / Animation
Director: Nishii Terumi / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Exactly halfway through all 24 episodes, the turning point episode.

A poignant, beautiful story about Margo, a man (robot) trying to repaint his town silver as proof of his existence.

The Margo drawn in the storyboard seemed like some old guy character, but the setting that came up from Umakoshi-san was a character that looked like "a girl?" at first glance. So I made the character's colour image "French artist" - white skin like a Caucasian + clear blue eyes. Incidentally, if it had been the old guy Margo from the storyboard, the image would have been a rather rough-haired red-haired Dutch artist.

"Silver" is quite difficult. One step wrong and it just looks like grey, and if you push it too far it becomes white solid colour. And then snow piles on top of that... Applause to the art staff who exquisitely distinguished such "silver."

Actually, this episode hit quite a spot for me personally. I suddenly thought "maybe I'm the same as Margo."

The episodic complete stories mostly ended with episode 12. Finally, in the latter half, the story would head toward the main plot.

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